NGO).

Yet another serious problem I noticed concerning the prisoners' health was their problem of smoking. Quarters in the jails are confined and smoking was creating bronchial and other respiratory tract problems even in non-smokers through passive smoking. But this was a problem in which very large numbers were involved and I kept my mind open to opportunities that might enable me to stop this. One day, on my rounds in the adolescent wards, I was standing behind a prisoner when he coughed and spat a little distance away. It landed in front of a boy sitting in his educational class. I pounced on the opportunity and declared to the lot sitting there that this was how a privilege given to inmates was being abused. Spitting into a class was sacrilege and if concessions like smoking were causing this then I had no option but to stop it henceforth. Smoking was immediately banned for the adolescents and strict instructions were issued that no visitor would bring *beedis* for his or her ward. Just like liquor brings a lot of money to the government's coffers so also were *beedis* and cigarettes bringing in a lot of money to the prisoners' welfare funds in the jails. But my superintendent agreed with me that we would rather bear the financial loss but we would ban consumption of tobacco in the jails. Since we had approached them at the psychological level the youngsters realized that it was because of their misuse of privileges that this ban had been imposed and therefore they were quite silent about it. They were all young with flexible and receptive minds and they opted for showing obedience to the ban orders. This affected their mind control a lot and they soon realized they were better off with the ban. They reported that spitting in the barracks had come to a stop. They were now living in cleaner barracks and a lot of their throat and chest problems had disappeared. That made us happy.

The problem now was with the more hardened and longer addicted adults! How should we set about effecting the ban for them? The opportunity presented itself one day. On one of our rounds in Jail 3 one of the prisoners attending classes pointed out to me that a particular prisoner was selling *beedis* in black, i.e., charging more than the normal rates. I asked him why he would be doing so when they were freely available in the jail canteen and he told me that sometimes the canteen would be closed for two days, or there would be a short supply. On being questioned, the concerned prisoner refuted the charge saying that the other had some personal enmity with him and that is why he was saying so. So I ordered a search of his belongings in his barracks and sure enough the search revealed a tin full of *beedis*. I took this opportunity to tell them that this privilege we had been giving them had been misused and that a criminal offence was being committed because of this. Blackmarketing would not be allowed to thrive in the prison and therefore I was going to impose a ban on smoking in all prisons. I drove on the initiative I had got and expressed my anger at them. Here I was, I told them, spending over one and a half crore of rupees on their health problems and at no cost would I let them undo all that I had been trying to do. I told them that here I was trying to cure them of TB and bronchial and other problems, and spending so much money on them, and they dared to take tonic from me and poison from the prisoners. No more would I permit this, I told them. If they wanted to continue taking the poison then let them pay for the cure. I certainly was not going to do it!

Immediately on imposing the ban market forces exerted themselves in the jails' townships. People started hoarding whatever stocks were available and there was a flourishing black market. We were aware this would happen, and we were also aware that this would last only till such time as the stock started to dry up. Massive searches were conducted and violators punished. Stocks soon petered out and so that concern of ours was over. The major concern,